Free Churro

By Raphael Bob-Waksberg

BOJACK: So I stopped at a Jack in the Box on the way here, and the girl behind the counter said, "Hiya! Are you having an awesome day?" Not, "How are you doing today?" No. "Are you having an awesome day?"

When people ask how I'm doing, I usually say, "I am doing so great." But when this girl at the Jack in the Box asked me if I was having an awesome day, I said, "Well, my mom died," and she immediately burst into tears.

So now I have to comfort her, which is annoying, and meanwhile, there's a line of people forming behind me who are giving me these real judgy looks because I made the Jack in the Box girl cry. She's saying, "I'm sorry, I'm so sorry," and I'm like, "It's fine. It's fine." I mean, it's not fine but, you know, it's. . . fine. And I would like to order a Double Jack Meal, and I've kinda got somewhere to be, so maybe . . . *[inhales]*

And the girl apologizes again and offers me a free churro with my meal. And as I'm leaving, I think, "I just got a free churro because my mom died." No one ever tells you that when your mom dies, you get a free churro.

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INTRODUCTION

Why do our parents matter so much? Well, our parental figures matter because they forge our idea of how the world works, often by accident. They create our sense of how to attach to people, how to navigate, and how to love. And there is no opting out of this influence. In this selection, BoJack has the opportunity to deliver the eulogy for his mother Bea. It was a relationship filled with maternal insults and critical judgments from a woman who believed she was 'born broken.'

You can hear every last bit of forced levity, resentment, and genuine pain as BoJack tries to find a way to come to terms with Bea's death, and his feelings or lack thereof. This episode of BoJack Horseman, (Season 5, Episode 6) was met with critical acclaim and was nominated for an Emmy.

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BOJACK: *[clears throat]* Anyway, I'm sorry, that's not part of the. . .*[clears throat]* All right, here we go. Let's do this. Beatrice Horseman, who was she? Uh, she was born in 1938. She died in 2018. One time, she went to a parade, and one time, she smoked an entire cigarette in one long inhale. Truly a remarkable woman.

Lived a full life, that lady. Life, right? Goes by, stuff happens. Then you die. But seriously, that's all I have to say about my mother. No point beating a dead horse, right? So. . . *[inhales]* Now what? Mom, you got any ideas? Anything? Mom? Nothing to contribute? Knock once if you're proud of me.

Can I just say how amazing it is to be in a room with my mother, and I can just talk without her telling me to shut up and make her a drink? Hey, Mom, knock once if you think I should shut up. No? You sure? I mean, I don't want to embarrass you.

Sorry about the closed casket, by the way. She wanted an open casket, but uh, you know, she's dead now, so who cares what she wanted? No, that sounds bad. I'm sorry. I-I think that if she could've seen what she looked like dead, she'd agree it's better this way. The coroner couldn't get her eyes closed, so now her face is forever frozen in a mask of tremendous horror and anguish. Or as my mom called it, Tuesday! Tuesday! My mom called it Tuesday.

Here's a story. When I was a teenager, I performed a comedy routine for my high school talent show. There was this, uh, cool jacket that I wanted to wear. For months, I saved up for this jacket. But when I finally had enough, I went to the store and it was gone. They had sold it to someone else. So, I went home and I told my mother, and she said, "That's the good that comes from wanting things." She was ***really*** good at dispensing life lessons that always seemed to circle back to everything being my fault.

But then, on the day of the talent show, my mother had a surprise for me. She had bought me the jacket. Even though she didn't know how to say it, I know this meant that she loved me. Now that's a good story about my mother. It's not true, but it's a good story, right? I don't have any stories like that.

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All I know about being good, I learned from TV. And in TV, flawed characters are constantly showing people they care with these surprising grand gestures. Part of me still believes that's what love is. But in real life, the big gesture isn't enough. You need to be consistent, you need to be dependably good. You can't just screw everything up and then take a boat out into the ocean to save your best friend, or solve a mystery, and fly to Kansas. You need to do it every day, which is so. . . hard.

When you're a kid, you convince yourself that maybe the grand gesture could be enough, that even though your parents aren't what you need them to be over and over and over again, at any moment, they might surprise you with something. . . wonderful. I kept waiting for that, the proof that even though my mother was a hard woman, deep down, she loved me and cared about me and wanted me to know that I made her life a little bit brighter. Even now, I find myself waiting.

Hey, Mom, knock once if you love me and care about me and want me to know I made your life a little bit brighter.

I was in the hospital with her those last moments, and they were truly horrifying, full of nonsencial screams and cries, but there was this moment, this one instant of strange calm, where she looked in my direction and said, "I see you." That's the last thing she said to me. "I see you." Not a statement of judgment or disappointment, just acceptance and the simple recognition of another person in a room. "Hello there. You are a person. And I see you."

Let me tell you, it's a weird thing to feel at [insert age here] years old, that for the first time in your life your mother sees you. It's an odd realization that that's the only thing you wanted all along, to be seen. I was not ready for "I see you." -- a moment of connection on her way out. But maybe I'm giving her too much credit. Maybe it wasn't about connection. Maybe it was an "I see you," like, "You might have the rest of the world fooled, but I know exactly who you are." That's more my mom's speed.

My dad died about ten years ago. My darling mother gave the eulogy. My entire life I

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never heard her say a kind word to or about my father, but at his funeral she said, “My husband is dead, and everything is worse now.”

“My husband is dead, and everything is worse now.” I don’t know why she said that. Maybe she felt like that’s the kind of thing you’re supposed to say at a funeral. Maybe she hoped one day someone would say that about her. “My mother is dead, and everything is worse now.” Or maybe she knew that he had frittered away all her inheritance and replaced it with crippling debt. “Bad news, you lost a husband, but don’t worry, you also lost the house!” Maybe Mom knew she’d have to sell all her fancy jewelry and move into a home. Maybe that’s what she meant by “everything is worse now.” Is that what you meant, Mom?

You know, the first time I ever performed in front of an audience was, uh, with my mom. She used to put on these shows with her supper club. There were skits and magic acts, and the finale was always a dance my mother did. She had this beautiful dress that she only brought out for these parties. It was so beautiful and sad.

Dad hated the parties. He’d lock himself in the study, but he always came out to see Mom dance. He’d linger in the doorway and watch in awe, as this cynical, despicable woman he married. . . took flight. And as a child who was completely terrified of both my parents, I was always aware that this moment of grace, it meant something. My mother, she knew what it’s like to feel your entire life like you’re drowning, with the exception of these moments, these very rare, brief instances, in which you suddenly remember. . . you can swim.

But then again, mostly not. Mostly you’re drowning. She understood that, too. All three of us were drowning, and we didn’t know how to save each other, but there was an understanding that we were all drowning together. And I would like to think that that’s what she meant when we were in the hospital and she said, “I see you.”

My mom left no instructions for what she wanted me to say. All I know is she wanted an open casket, and her idiot son couldn’t even do that right. I’m not gonna stand up here

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and pretend I ever understood how to please that woman, even though so much of my life has been wasted in vain attempts to figure it out. But I keep going back to that moment in the ICU when she looked at me, and… "I-C-U." "I… see… you." Jesus Christ, we were in the intensive care unit. She was just reading a sign.

My mom died and all I got was this free churro. The s****iest thing about all of this is when that stranger gave me that free churro, that small act of kindness showed more compassion than my mother gave me her entire life. Like, how hard is it to do something nice for a person? This woman at the Jack in the Box didn't even know me. I'm your son! All I had was you! *[inhales]*

I have this friend. And right around when I first met her, her dad died, and I actually went with her to the funeral. And months later, she told me that she didn't understand why she was still upset, because she never even liked her father. It made sense to me, because I went through the same thing when my dad died. And I'm going through the same thing now.

Suddenly, you realize you'll never have the good relationship you wanted, and even though you'd never admit it, part of you, the stupidest part of you, was holding on to that chance. And you didn't even realize it until that chance went away.

My mother is dead, and everything is worse now, because now I know I will never have a mother who looks at me from across a room and says, "I see you." But I guess it's good to know that there is nobody looking out for me, that there never was, and there never will be. No, it's good to know that I am the only one that I can depend on. And I know that now and it's good. It's good that I know that. So. . . it's good my mother is dead.

Beatrice Horseman was born in 1938, and she died in 2018, and I have no idea. . .what she wanted. Unless she just wanted what we all want. . . to be seen.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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